



HOW TO **re**search *T H I R D E D I T I O N*



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All at sea but learning to swim

Introduction • The first time researcher • Getting a flavour of possibilities • Why am I doing this research? • Will I have anything new to say? • In whose interests is this research? • At last, writing up • How to use this book • What's different about this edition? • Summary • Exercises • Further reading

Introduction

This book focuses on the processes of research as well as research methods. It aims to demystify research, recognizing the everyday skills and techniques involved. It encourages you to think of research as a kind of spiral through which you revisit the various stages of the process, but always with different and developed insights. The book is multidisciplinary in scope. It is designed to be suitable for those undertaking research in the social sciences, as well as in related subjects such as education, business studies and health and social care.

Are you currently feeling *all at sea* and not knowing in which direction to turn with your research project? Or is your research *going swimmingly* and you are *steaming ahead* sure in the knowledge that you are doing a good job? Perhaps you are fluctuating between the ends of this spectrum. You have a sense of *drowning* at one moment in the size of the task ahead, and then *floating* serenely along at the next moment content with the work you have produced so far. Maybe you are *treading water* and feeling your work has come to a standstill. Or perhaps you are at the stage of *dipping your feet* into icy cold waters for a



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short *paddle* in order to test the water, before you *take the plunge* and begin your research.

As a new, or not so new, researcher, such feelings are common. Indeed, we could say that they go with the territory of research. There is excitement at the prospect of discovering new insights into a topic of interest. There is a sense of confusion over what you are meant to be doing and when. You are aware that you have the ability to build on your current skills and aptitudes to complete the task ahead successfully. But this can be undermined by a hint of fear that maybe you are not really up to the mark of undertaking what is, after all, a major form of independent study.

Surviving and feeling that you are thriving across the period of your study is, therefore, an important goal, as this will enable you to maintain motivation when things get tough, and to develop a sense of competence and expertise in the conduct of your work. This book is about the practice and experience of doing research, and is designed to ensure that you survive and thrive. It is aimed at those, particularly the less experienced, who are involved in small-scale research projects. It is intended to be useful to both those doing research, whether for academic credit or not, and those responsible for teaching, supervising or managing new researchers.

However, to survive and thrive does not simply mean staying in *familiar seas*. As a person involved in learning, surviving as a research student is about accumulating knowledge and extending skills. Thriving as a research student can be helped by anticipating the sorts of skills, the different forms of knowledge and the resources that you will need. This involves looking ahead and doing some preparation. It means that you need to simulate *stormy seas* in order to begin to develop the *swimming* skills that you need to thrive.

With this in mind, this opening chapter is designed to encourage you to look ahead in several senses. Through a series of case studies, this chapter takes you through key aspects of the research process. These range from getting started to writing up. In addition, this chapter introduces you to a number of common dilemmas and concerns facing research students. These include maintaining motivation, understanding the meanings of originality, and exploring issues of truth, power and values. Overall, this chapter is designed to encourage you to gain a sense of the route you are taking, because if you don't know the destination, how are you going to get there? Happy swimming!

The chapter is organized into the following sections:

- **The first time researcher.** Undertaking an audit of the skills, knowledge and resources you already possess, and developing a Personal Development Plan for the successful completion of your research.
- **Getting a flavour of possibilities.** Introducing some elements of research design and developing understandings of the varied nature of research.
- **Why am I doing this research?** Exploring your motivations for undertaking research.
- **Will I have anything new to say?** Debunking the idea of originality.

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- **In whose interests is this research?** Issues of truth, power and values and the context of your research.
- **At last, writing up.** Planning ahead means ensuring you know the rules, regulations and audiences for your research.
- **How to use this book.** What you will find in it, and how to make your way through it.
- **What is different about this edition?** What has changed and what has been added since the second edition.

The chapter ends with a summary.

The first time researcher

John has an appointment to see his dissertation supervisor. He is worried. He has no idea what topic he might research or even a clear idea about the different kinds of methodological techniques available to him. His assumption is that it is only great men, who have far more superior skills and knowledge than he might ever possess, who actually do 'real' research. But his intellectual anxieties are only one of his concerns. He also has doubts whether he will be organized enough to complete a piece of work that he will have to design and execute himself. To date, his only experiences of education have been on courses with set tasks and readings. This dissertation is really going to test him. 'Am I up to it?', he thinks, as he knocks on the supervisor's door.

In our experience, it doesn't really matter what level you are studying at, doing research usually provokes a series of anxieties. You might be asked to undertake research for an 'A' level module or as part of your undergraduate degree. You may be writing a dissertation for an MA or a PhD thesis. At the outset you may, therefore, be feeling all at sea, wondering what is expected and how you are going to cope. Indeed, it is often the case that these anxieties and worries occur *despite* other positive experiences of research. For example, you might be embarking on your undergraduate dissertation having already written methodological essays for a research methods module. Or you might be beginning your PhD having recently completed a 15,000 word MA dissertation. Whatever your situation, as a first time researcher or a not-quite-first-time researcher, you are likely to experience various concerns and worries. In such a situation, it is easy to forget that by the time you are required to undertake first-hand research, you already have a wide knowledge and sets of skills that have been developed to enable you to be successful.

Our intention in this book is to give you the skills and confidence that will take you successfully from the initial idea to a completed piece of research. With this in mind, there is no better time to start than now. Whatever your



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level, you will be beginning this particular research project with a host of skills, resources and knowledge derived from your education and life experiences to date. These skills will be technical (e.g. use of information retrieval systems such as libraries and the Internet) and social (e.g. working collaboratively with fellow students, getting on with others). Resources will include social resources (e.g. family, friends, teachers), emotional resources (e.g. resilience) and material resources (e.g. time and money). And of course, you will have knowledge about your subject area (e.g. sociology, psychology, education, business studies, health, etc.).

One way of gaining a sense of the skills, resources and knowledge you already possess is to undertake an audit. You can do this by completing Exercise 1.1 at the end of the chapter. Exercise 1.1 should provide you with the base line you are working from. However, there is no doubt that undertaking first-hand research will require you – and indeed will enable you – to increase your skill and knowledge levels, to work more independently and to have a greater sense of self-direction.

The gap between the level you are working at now and the level required for successful completion of your research project represents your personal learning needs. In order to produce a development plan that will enable you to meet these learning needs, you will need to assess the adequacy of your current skills, resources and knowledge for the task you are now facing. Do you, for example, need to have a higher level of skill in searching for existing research relating to your topic using Internet search engines or specialist journal sources? Or are there specific knowledge areas relating to your topic that you need to be more familiar with? For example, if your research is concerned with the role of professionalism in nursing, are you required to have an understanding of the changing nature of professionalism in a range of employment fields? Moreover, do you need to have a better appreciation of the financial resources you will need for your research?

Some of the resources, skills and knowledge you possess will, though, be more than adequate for the task ahead. Exercise 1.2 is designed to help you work out where the specific gaps are, and to identify your learning needs. Exercise 1.2 should have highlighted four issues:

- 1 That you already possess some of the main elements that will contribute to you successfully completing your dissertation or project. When things get tough don't forget this.
- 2 That, in terms of skills and knowledge, you have some learning needs that need addressing in either the short or the long term.
- 3 That you have resource needs that need addressing.
- 4 That there are some areas of skill, knowledge and resources that you are unsure or unclear about and, in consequence, need to explore further.

In terms of your learning needs, it is at this point that you should consider creating a Personal Development Plan. Such a plan can be relatively simple in

that it records three aspects which will be central for the successful completion of your project: your identified learning needs; how they are going to be met; and the planned timescale for meeting these. An example is provided in Box 1.1.

For resource needs and areas where you are unclear or do not yet have sufficient information, it is worthwhile identifying the sources of help that will address these. Box 1.2 provides a list of some of the potential ones that we have identified.

Box 1.1 An example of a Personal Development Plan

Identified learning need?	How will I achieve this need?	What is my timescale?
Settle on a topic	Talk to friends and other students Work through Chapter 2 of this book	In the next week
Review existing research on my topic	Conduct a range of literature reviews	In the next 6 weeks
Questionnaire design	Consult textbooks and supervisor Look at examples in other research	In the next 2 weeks In the next 3 weeks
Qualitative data analysis	Attend a course	In the next 4 months

Box 1.2 Some potential sources of help

- Your supervisor
- Your fellow students
- The departmental secretary
- University or college services (counselling, information technology, careers, library)
- Specialist departments (e.g. computing, English language support)
- Student union
- Your manager
- Other work colleagues, particularly those who have undertaken similar research projects recently
- Family
- Friends
- Lecturers/supervisors/teachers from previous courses of study
- The various handbooks that your department or school provide
- The various textbooks that have been written for research students (including, of course, this one)

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So far, our aim has been to encourage you to recognize that you bring valuable skills, knowledge and resources to your research. You already possess many of the requirements that are necessary for success at this stage. We have also encouraged you to recognize that you can contribute to the likelihood of your being successful through developing an understanding of your learning and resource needs, both for the immediate future and in the longer term. This means that, as well as looking back at what you have learnt and understood, you also need to look forward to what will be required. Now is the time, therefore, to draft your Personal Development Plan (see Exercise 1.3).

Getting a flavour of possibilities

'Well, that wasn't too bad', Samia thought, as she left her supervisor's office. I now know that all that reading I did on Malthusian economics might pay off for me. And my IT skills are in pretty good shape. I still don't really have a handle on the variety of different kinds of research though. My supervisor said I might think about what kinds of methodological approaches I prefer. Do I want to do numbers or do I want to talk to people? The only research I really know about is surveys and questionnaires. I hadn't given any thought to something like spending long periods of time with a small group of people and doing participant observation. But she said it was a possibility. And I never even knew that I could base the whole of the design of my project on library research. I had always thought that was just the literature review part of it. I will have to give some thought to the different types of research and see if any appeal or are possible.

It is often not fully appreciated that, at the very earliest stages of thinking about research, there are many ways in which this might proceed. For example, say your general topic was 'Asylum Seekers in the UK'. You might research this in any, and indeed all, of the following ways:

- By gathering together existing statistics
- Looking at policy at local and national level
- Exploring the responses of relevant charitable organizations
- Devising a questionnaire for various 'stakeholders' in this field
- Conducting interviews with asylum seekers
- Living among asylum seekers over a period of time
- Undertaking an analysis of media representations of asylum seekers

Your decision on how you might proceed clearly depends upon a number of factors. The most significant of these is what you are interested in finding out. For example, if your research questions whether the numbers of asylum seekers coming to the UK are increasing or decreasing, which countries they

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are travelling from, and what sex and age they are, then an analysis of existing statistics would be a very useful place to start. You would then be in a position to use percentages and bar charts to demonstrate your findings. Alternatively, if you are more interested in the experiences of asylum seekers once they have arrived in the UK, then you might consider interviews or even try to spend some time living among them as a form of participant observation. Your project or dissertation would then present the words of your research participants or extracts from your research diary detailing, for example, something of daily life for a particular group of asylum seekers.

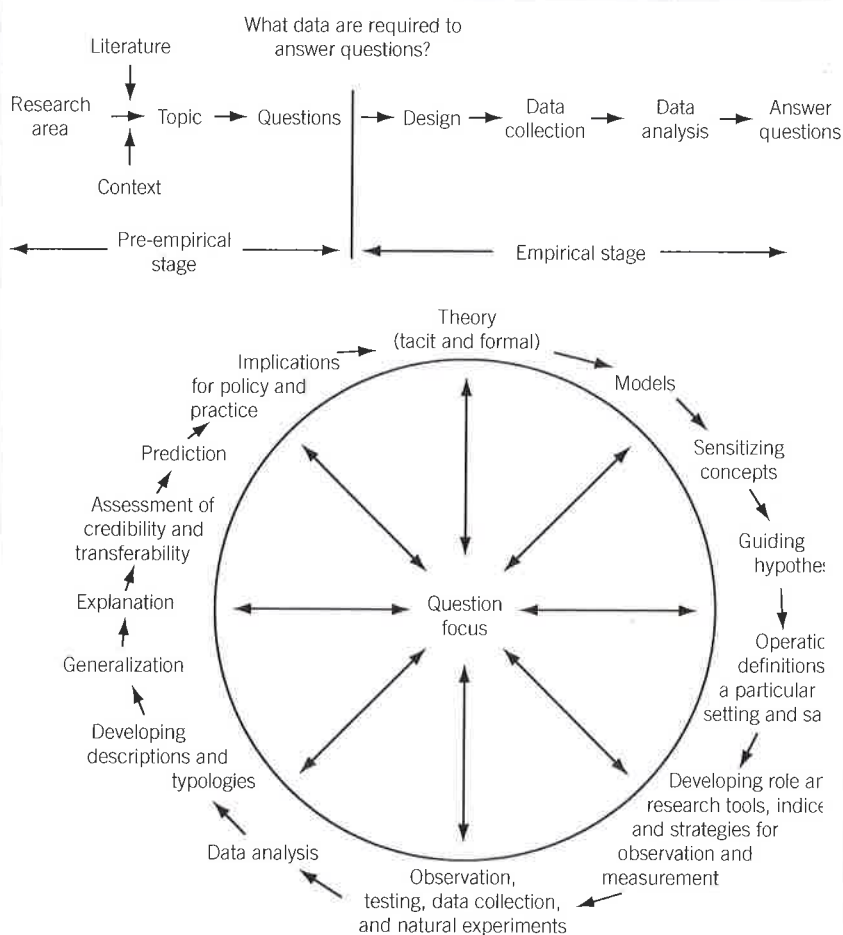
The section on **Focusing** in Chapter 2, particularly Box 2.8, considers the issues involved in drafting a research proposal.

In addition, your methodological decisions will depend upon how much time you have available, the expected word length of your project or dissertation, your research skills, the regulations and preferences of your department, school, examination board, manager and/or supervisor, what and whom you are able to access, the ethical parameters of your proposal and your own preferences. These represent some very practical concerns, and you would be well advised to consult with your supervisor or manager at the very outset.

For example, if you are thinking of conducting an interview-based study and you are completing a 10,000 word MA dissertation conducted over a 3 month period, you might plan to interview between six to eight people once only. By comparison, for a PhD of 80,000 words conducted over a 3 year period and using a qualitative research approach, you might be expected to have an in-depth knowledge of the lives of your research respondents, and be planning to spend an equivalent of 12 months conducting fieldwork. If you are planning to take a more quantitative approach and you are an undergraduate student undertaking a dissertation, you are unlikely to have the resources, in terms of time and money, available to conduct a large-scale survey. Secondary data analysis may, therefore, be a more fruitful strategy. Conversely, if you are conducting a quantitatively based PhD, then you should expect to have already, and to acquire further, a high level of statistical ability.

The ways in which your research questions and interests shape the possible design of your research combine with practical issues such as time, resources and abilities. Accordingly, they each contribute to the ways in which your project will proceed. With this in mind, take a look at the representations of research shown in Box 1.3. These diagrams give alternative views of the research process. The most standard understanding of research is that showing a linear design, where the research begins with a problem and proceeds through data collection and analysis to the written report. The other diagram shows a far more iterative approach. This design seeks to convey the inter-relationship between data collection, analysis and report writing. These two

Box 1.3 Representations of the research process



(Sources: Marshall and Rossman 1999: 26; Punch 2005: 40)

representations may be understood as lying towards the polar ends of a continuum where, between these points, there are many variations.

Indeed, there are at least four common viewpoints when it comes to conveying and understanding the various processes of research:

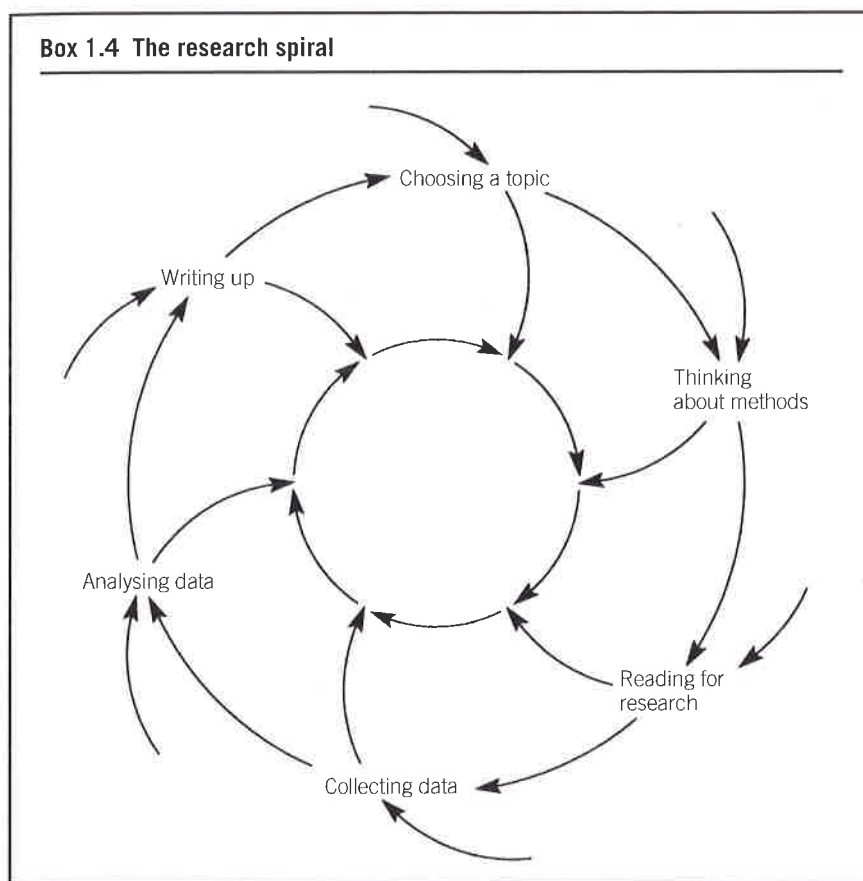
- Research is often presented as a fixed, linear series of stages, with a clear start and end. This is the 'standard' view.
- There are also somewhat more complicated representations of this linear

view that allow for slightly different routes to be taken through the process at particular stages.

- Another common representation portrays research as a circular process, analogous to the more general process of learning. Much the same set of stages is included, and in much the same order as in the linear view, but there is an implication both that the process might be entered at a number of points, and that the experience of later stages might lead to a reinterpretation or revisiting of earlier stages.
- There are also variants, often associated with action research, that see the research process as cyclical. Here, the process is shown as going through a number of cycles, the effects of each one impacting upon the way in which successive cycles are approached.

Our preferred view builds on these representations, seeing the research process as a spiral (see Box 1.4). Seen from this perspective, research: is cyclical; can be

Box 1.4 The research spiral





entered at almost any point; is a never ending process; will cause you to reconsider your practice; and will return you to a different starting place.

The nature of the cycle varies between research designs. For example, in most quantitative research projects, decisions about analysis have to be taken before any fieldwork or data collection is undertaken. This is because the types of statistical techniques that are possible vary with the types of data collected. In the case of qualitative research, by contrast, data collection, sorting, analysis and reading can take place simultaneously. Getting a flavour of each of the possible – even ideal – ways your project might proceed is an important part of the initial stage. This will enable you to select the most appropriate research process for your needs and interests, and to develop a sense of the limitations of the one you do select. This will also enable you to develop an understanding of the implications of your research approach, in terms of when the different elements are staged and accomplished, and in terms of what you might expect about the process and your associated experiences.

Why am I doing this research?

Helen is sitting in the library. She has several books on the desk in front of her. One is open but unread. The others are stacked in short piles giving the look of a stockade around her. Her notepad is open, the page already containing her first embryonic notes and several doodles. She has spent the best part of the morning searching for these texts, and counts herself lucky that at least some of those on her list were actually still on the shelves. And she had a breakthrough the other day as she had decided that her research design would be based on qualitative approaches. Yet now she's got herself organized to this stage, she is wondering why she's doing this research. Is it really going to be that interesting a topic? Isn't there too much (i.e. boring) preparatory work to do before she can really get going? She would much rather get out there talking to and interviewing people. But, actually, even that seems too much effort now. Maybe it's best to pack up. Start another day. Not do it at all . . .

While there are many highs when doing research, it also has to be acknowledged that there will be many moments when the task ahead appears daunting or tedious, or simply not worth the effort. It is important, therefore, to remind yourself, from time to time, of why you are undertaking, or interested in undertaking, research. Quite often professional researchers are initially motivated by hopes that their work will change the world in some way. There are also many researchers who reflect upon how their initial choice of topic was motivated by their personal circumstances or something that is close to their personal interests. For example, stepmothers may study stepfamilies, or non-traditional students' may study the experiences of other non-traditional



students. Of course, research is a job like any other. Researchers, therefore, often undertake studies on topics that are not of their personal choosing, but because they pay the rent or may take them on to the next stage of their career. Think about your reasons for doing your project and try to complete Exercise 1.4.

As a researcher, you will find it useful to understand why you are involved in research. This will affect how you go about your research, and what you get out of it. If you are in doubt about your motivation, or reach a low spot when you feel that you want to give up, you might ask yourself the following questions:

- What are the personal rewards from completing this study? For example, how will the award of the qualification associated with your research enhance your career and employment prospects? What new skills will you have acquired? Will your research have enabled you to develop new contacts or visit new places? Will it have enabled you to demonstrate hitherto hidden competencies to significant others? What kinds of satisfaction will you experience once the last word is written on the last page?
- How will the knowledge you produce contribute to furthering understandings or changing lives? Most often this question is understood in terms of large-scale change through, for example, finding the ultimate solution to a perennial problem. However, most contributions from research tend to be smaller in scale, though no less significant in terms of their importance to the individuals involved. For example, your research respondents may feel that this is the first time anyone has ever taken a real interest in their concerns. After all, it is quite rare – outside of therapeutic encounters – for anyone to sit down, listen intently and record everything you say for an hour or so. Research can, therefore, be a very important validating experience for research respondents. The enthusiasm you garner from being involved in research can also be very persuasive for others who may develop insights from, or become more interested in, the issues arising from your research. This can create incremental and cascading changes that, while they may not rock the world immediately, nonetheless become significant in themselves.

But what might you do if you really feel you have no motivation at all? After all, if you aren't motivated, or are not motivated very strongly, this will affect your drive to finish the research project successfully. The obvious answer to the researcher with no motivation is to get some quickly or do something else! If the latter is not possible, you might seek motivation in one of the following ways:

- changing your research project to something you are more interested in;
- focusing on the skills you will develop through undertaking the research;
- incorporating within the research some knowledge acquisition of relevance to you;



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- seeing the research project as part of a larger activity, which will have knock-on benefits for your work, your career, your social life or your life in general;
- finding someone who will support you and push you through until you finish;
- promising yourself a reward when it is successfully completed.

If you are still troubled by your lack of motivation, have a look at the section in Chapter 2 on **What to do if you can't think of a topic.**

Will I have anything new to say?

It's all been done before. Everything I was planning to do I can now see that other researchers have done before. What's the point, then, of carrying on? Hussain felt a strong sense of rising panic as the deadline for handing in his dissertation was fast approaching. He had completed all the data collection and had also completed quite a lot of the analysis. He realized that his findings were not terribly new to anyone who knew his research field. They also confirmed much of what he had previously thought was the case.

For many research projects, particularly those carried out for a university degree, there is often a need for some kind or level of originality. This will typically be expressed in regulations or guidance in very general terms: 'an original project', 'an original contribution' or 'evidence of original thinking'.

But what is originality? And where can you get some? If you are unsure, and it matters to you in your research, take a look at Box 1.5. Here you will find 15 definitions of originality, collected together by others. Have a look at them and consider if your research meets any of the criteria listed. As the definitions quoted indicate, it is possible to be original in terms of topic, approach or presentation. The element of originality in your own research is, realistically, likely to be very small. Highly original research is very unusual, and you are probably setting your sights far too high if you try aiming for it.

The corollary of this is that your research is almost certainly original in some way, always providing, that is, that you are not slavishly copying someone else's earlier research. So be reassured. Indeed, it is quite common for researchers to become so familiar with their topic that they forget that it was all new to them when they started. While good researchers need to be over-familiar with the relevant literature, their data and their findings, this can lead to a mistaken assumption that everyone else is as knowledgeable as they are. Researchers therefore forget their initial excitement and interest in gaining

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**Box 1.5 Fifteen definitions of originality**

Here are 15 definitions of originality, as put together by Phillips and Pugh. The first six are derived from a previous author, Francis, while the other nine derive from interviews with Australian students, supervisors and examiners.

- 1 Setting down a major piece of new information in writing for the first time.
- 2 Continuing a previously original piece of work.
- 3 Carrying out original work designed by the supervisor.
- 4 Providing a single original technique, observation or result in an otherwise unoriginal but competent piece of research.
- 5 Having many original ideas, methods and interpretations all performed by others under the direction of the postgraduate.
- 6 Showing originality in testing somebody else's idea.
- 7 Carrying out empirical work that hasn't been done before.
- 8 Making a synthesis that hasn't been made before.
- 9 Using already known material but with a new interpretation.
- 10 Trying out something in this country that has previously only been done in other countries.
- 11 Taking a particular technique and applying it in a new area.
- 12 Bringing new evidence to bear on an old issue.
- 13 Being cross-disciplinary and using different methodologies.
- 14 Looking at areas that people in the discipline haven't looked at before.
- 15 Adding to knowledge in a way that hasn't previously been done before.

(Source: Phillips and Pugh 2005: 62; partly after Francis 1976)

new knowledge and, in consequence, they forget that what they have to say may well be novel and new to other audiences. But if you are in doubt, check it out with those who will judge the originality of your research as early as possible. This advice also applies if you fear that you may be being too original for comfort. If you want to complete a useful piece of research in a particular context, it would not be sensible to, for example, present it in a way which is unacceptable.

In whose interests is this research?

Rishi thought his research was telling the facts of the case. He was very pleased that he had proven how poor the management was at Britwell and Company. He was shocked when his supervisor told him that all he could say was that 'such and such' was someone's perspective. Actually he said that Rishi needed to



consider how much his values and experiences had impacted upon the selection of data and the analysis. It wasn't a perspective, Rishi raged, it was the truth. The management were lazy and inept. All of his research respondents told him so.

Many people coming to research for the first time have a tendency to think that they are in the business of establishing 'the truth' about a particular issue or subject. They want to find out 'the facts' or want to 'prove' (or perhaps disprove) a particular argument. They believe that they can be 'objective' in their research and that others will sit up and take notice when they present their findings. We shouldn't be surprised that this is the case because the 'standard' view of research is that of a detached scientist examining the facts of the case coolly and unemotionally. However, this standard view of research belies the extent to which, as we have suggested, research is a social activity that can be powerfully affected by the researcher's own motivations and values. It also takes place within a broader social context, within which politics and power relations influence what research is undertaken, how it is carried out and whether and how it is reported and acted upon. To examine how this affects the different forms of data that can be collected, its subsequent analysis and findings, try Exercise 1.5.

Exercise 1.5 suggests how politics, power and values may be important considerations for your research, especially if you carry it out within your own or another organization. Your contacts will affect your access to the subjects of your research, may require you to submit your research proposals for scrutiny, and to revise them, and may exercise some veto over what you can actually write up or publish. If your research requires ethical approval prior to proceeding, which is increasingly likely to be the case, you will be required to adhere to a broader set of values and ways of proceeding, regardless of whether your research is organizationally based or not. And, if you are unlucky, misread the organizational politics or irritate the researched, you may find cooperation withdrawn part way through your project.

It is important, therefore, to understand the perspectives and motivations of those who facilitate your access, or take part in, or who may be stakeholders in, your research. Preparatory time spent in learning about this is always well spent, as well as being valuable contextual research in its own right. Rather than expecting to 'find the truth', therefore, it is better to think of research work in terms of words like rigour, reliability, professionalism and systematization. No one research project can realistically aspire to do more than advance our understanding in some way. Most researchers have to compromise their practices to fit into the time and other resources available for their studies. Doing research is, therefore, about producing something that is 'good enough' rather than providing the last final word of truth on a particular topic.

This does not mean, of course, that such research cannot be pursued with drive, passion and commitment. These are important qualities that help maintain momentum and interest, and can impact beyond the research into



dissemination. However, all researchers need to take care that their passion does not lead to dogma or an uncritical take on the views of research participants. Rather, researchers need to maintain their levels of critical reflection, and so ensure their research is conducted in as open and transparent a way as possible in terms of its intentions, methodology, analysis and findings.

At last, writing up

The data had all been collected. The analysis was virtually complete. Now is the time to switch on the word file and begin to write it all up. But hang on, thought Becky, how do I do this? What is the format? I've never written a dissertation before. Do I need an index and chapters? Or do I just set it all down like an essay? How many references should I use? Do I have enough? Or maybe, lucky me, I have too many? Then again, I promised to give a copy to the manager of the call centre where I conducted the research. She was really keen to see it because she's hoping it will help her improve productivity. Will she want to read all this literature review stuff? Also, how is she going to take some of the things the staff had to say about her? Oh dear . . .

It may seem that the writing up stage is a long way off, but it is important to consider the rules, regulations and expectations of the various audiences for your research early on. For example, if you are researching for a university degree or another form of formal qualification, you will have to produce a dissertation or a thesis that will be assessed according to academic criteria. It may be, however, that you are carrying out a research project for your employer, who will expect a concise report emphasizing the implications of your findings and recommending action. You may be balancing both of these roles. However, while the processes may be broadly similar, the outputs are likely to look very different.

For more advice here, look at the section in Chapter 8 on **Whom am I writing for?**

Your audience may also include those you are researching, whether at work or within a community organization. If the latter, your approach may be to work from the bottom up, gaining consensus and support from all involved throughout the process; and the research may be as much about the change and development engendered in your audience as about any written output.

The important theme which runs through this discussion is your need, as a researcher, to be aware of the context in which you are researching. This manifests itself in rules, whether written or unwritten. You need to be aware



of these rules and to follow them if you wish to succeed. You cannot hope just to muddle along and not run into problems.

Hint: Open a file on 'Regulations and Expectations'. Include copies of all the written regulations that apply to your research project and add notes on any unwritten expectations which you may find out about during your work.

How to use this book

The organization of the book

If you have already leafed through this book, or looked at the contents page, you will probably have noticed that it is organized in the kind of sequential, linear fashion which we criticized earlier in this chapter when discussing different representations of the research process. It is difficult to organize a book in any other way.

Thus, there are nine chapters, as follows:

- 1 **All at sea but learning to swim**, which considers the knowledge, skills and resources required, and the associated processes and concerns of research.
- 2 **Getting started**, which discusses how to focus your research project.
- 3 **Thinking about methods**, which examines the most common approaches and techniques used in research.
- 4 **Reading for research**, which discusses how and what to read, and reading as a source of data.
- 5 **Managing your project**, which deals with the planning and progressing of the work.
- 6 **Collecting data**, which considers the techniques and issues involved in data collection.
- 7 **Analysing data**, which examines how you can record, analyse and interpret different kinds of data.
- 8 **Writing up**, which deals with the organization and drafting of your report or thesis.
- 9 **Finishing off**, which looks at how to complete your project and what you might do afterwards.

The elements of the book

In looking at this book, you will probably also have noticed that it does not consist of straightforward text, but is composed of a number of elements. These are:



- The **text** itself, which is designed to offer guidance and lead you through the book.
- A series of over one hundred **boxes**, which provide summaries, illustrations, examples and lists relevant to the issues discussed in the text.
- A range of **exercises**, located at the end of each chapter, which are designed to get you thinking about some of the issues raised in the context of your own research plans and experiences.
- Dozens of **quotations**, either in the text or in boxes, exemplifying and illustrating both the experience of other researchers and their insights into researching.
- Up-to-date and extensive **annotated bibliographies** of relevant books on the topics covered, at the end of each chapter, with an indication of their contents.
- At the end of the book, a complete list of the **references** mentioned in the text.
- Within the text, **cross-references** to guide you between parts of the book.
- Occasional **hints**, tips and health warnings, designed to keep you on track.

We have adopted this varied presentational form to help you, the reader, to engage with what are rich and complex issues and debates, but without using complicated language. It is also intended to encourage different ways of using the book and its contents.

As social scientists trained in three different disciplines – anthropology, sociology and geography respectively – we have tried to include examples and illustrations from across the range of the social sciences. You will, however, find traces of our biographies throughout the book.

How to find your way through the book

There are many possible ways of using this book. The approach you adopt will depend upon your experience and preferences, the other support you are receiving and the kind of research project you are engaged in. You may, for example, already be well into your research by the time you pick up this book, and be looking for guidance on specific issues; or you may not have started yet and be scouting around for general advice.

Among the different ways in which you might use this book we may identify the following:

- You could start at the beginning and read through to the end. Though this is commonly perceived as the normal way to read a book, and to conduct research, we do not imagine that many of you will be doing this.
- You could start by reading Chapter 4, **Reading for research**, and then work both backwards and forwards from there.



- You could scan the contents page, read this introductory chapter, flick through the other chapters and sections, and then focus your attention on the pages that are of current interest to you.
- You could use the index to find references to topics that concern you.
- You could use the book as a basis for discussion, dialogue or exchange of ideas between yourself and others engaged in similar research projects.
- If you are involved in teaching or supervising those undertaking research, you might use the book as a source for exercises or ideas.

These are just some of the possibilities. We do not wish to restrict the ways in which you might use the book. Indeed, we would see your use of it as in many ways paralleling the research process itself: starting at any point, jumping from place to place, doing several things simultaneously, returning with renewed understanding to places you have already visited. To help you in this process, we have built in lots of cross-references between the different sections.

We would welcome your ideas on and responses to the book. If you would like to make a suggestion, please contact the authors through the publishers.

What's different about this edition?

In producing this third edition, we have drawn on the many helpful suggestions made by readers, and our own experiences, since the first edition was published in 1996. In particular, we have:

- thoroughly updated the bibliographies and references, to reflect contemporary concerns and issues in social research;
- added new examples and illustrations;
- revised the format by moving all exercises to the end of each chapter;
- completely revised Chapter 1, using a case study format and introducing new material on identifying and addressing learning needs.

We hope that you find this edition even more useful than the last one!

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Summary

Having read this chapter, you should:

- have an awareness of the skills, knowledge and resources you already possess that will enable you to survive stormy waters ahead;
- have an awareness of the skills, knowledge and resources that you need to enhance or acquire to enable you to thrive through your research work;
- now recognize the need to produce a Personal Development Plan;
- have some understanding of the variety of activities which may be considered as being 'research';
- appreciate that the research process is not straightforward, predictable or linear;
- have a clearer idea of your own motivations for engaging in research and of the context for your research;
- be more confident about your own ability to carry out a small-scale research project.

Exercises

- 1.1 What skills, resources and knowledge do you already have? Identify as many of the following as you can that have contributed to your success in academic work in the past: skills (e.g. information technology, reading, writing, managing time); resources (e.g. time, money, support networks); knowledge (e.g. subject knowledge, research knowledge, knowledge of systems, processes); your personality/temperament.
- 1.2 Expanding on past successes. Using the list of skills, resources and knowledge that you have produced in Exercise 1.1, identify those areas that: you know are adequate for your current needs; you know need developing for your future needs; or where you are unsure whether you have a high enough level of a particular skill, resource or knowledge.
- 1.3 My Personal Development Plan. To produce a personal development plan, you should enter at least one item under each of the following headings: Identified learning need? How will I achieve this need? What is my timescale? Review your Plan periodically as your research progresses.
- 1.4 Reasons for undertaking research. List your reasons for your current or anticipated involvement in research. List as many as you can think of.
- 1.5 The context of your research. Imagine you are doing research on experiences of training at work, whether within your own company or another. Would your findings be different if you approached your interviewees through: the managing director, the personnel manager, the shop



stewards' committee, the unemployment centre? How might they differ? How might this affect your conclusions? What if you had to write a report of your conclusions for each of these audiences? You can think about this as an exercise in finding out what is safe and what is risky in terms of expectations, theory, styles of writing, etc.

Further reading

As this is the first chapter in the book, and designed to be introductory, no specific suggestions for further reading will be given here. If you are keen to read more at this stage, however, you might look at the suggestions for the next chapter, or any of the other chapters. In many cases, of course, the items referred to could have been listed in more than one chapter, and contain sections that are relevant to a number of chapters.

We have designed the annotated bibliographies, included in the further reading sections at the end of the following eight chapters, to enable you to:

- browse through and identify texts which are likely to be of particular interest to you;
- identify books which focus on social science research in general, and those which are specific to particular disciplines or subject areas;
- quickly access deeper, more detailed or more theoretical treatments of the social research process.

The bibliographies have been restricted to books in print. You will find that they vary considerably in length, with those for Chapters 3, 6 and 7, which cover research methods and the collection and analysis of data, being particularly extensive. The list of further reading included in Chapter 9, the final chapter, is also relatively long, as this includes more theoretical and extended treatments for those who wish, or need, to probe the literature in more detail.

Please note that if a book isn't listed this doesn't mean that we think it's not very good – it's probably that we just haven't got round to reading it yet!